

Psalms 141

Set a Watch, O Lord

Set a watch, O Lord, before my mouth; keep the door of my lips
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *LORD, I cry unto thee: make haste unto me; give ear unto my voice, when I cry unto thee.*
- 2 *Let my prayer be set forth before thee as incense; and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice.*
- 3 *Set a watch, O LORD, before my mouth; keep the door of my lips.*
- 4 *Incline not my heart to any evil thing, to practise wicked works with men that work iniquity: and let me not eat of their dainties.*
- 5 *Let the righteous smite me; it shall be a kindness: and let him reprove me; it shall be an excellent oil, which shall not break my head: for yet my prayer also shall be in their calamities.*
- 6 *When their judges are overthrown in stony places, they shall hear my words; for they are sweet.*
- 7 *Our bones are scattered at the grave's mouth, as when one cutteth and cleaveth wood upon the earth.*
- 8 *But mine eyes are unto thee, O GOD the Lord: in thee is my trust; leave not my soul destitute.*
- 9 *Keep me from the snares which they have laid for me, and the gins of the workers of iniquity.*
- 10 *Let the wicked fall into their own nets, whilst that I withal escape.*

2 · CONTEXT

David prays not only for protection from external enemies but for internal discipline—guarded speech, a heart resistant to evil influence, and openness to correction from righteous friends rather than flattery from the wicked. The psalm treats prayer itself as an offering, comparable to incense and the evening sacrifice, and closes with the familiar plea to escape the snares set by enemies. Henry highlights the psalm's rare combination of self-watchfulness alongside prayer for deliverance, refusing to separate personal integrity from external danger.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

David asks God to hear him speedily and to receive his prayer as incense, the lifting of his hands as an evening sacrifice—prayer itself framed as worship offered, not merely a request submitted.

Verse 3-4

The request turns inward: set a watch before my mouth, keep the door of my lips, incline my heart away from evil, and let me not participate in wicked deeds or delicacies with those who do evil. Guarding speech and desire is requested as urgently as any external protection.

Verse 5-7

David welcomes correction from the righteous as a kindness—an excellent oil he refuses to reject—even while continuing to pray against the deeds of the wicked. Difficult circumstances follow, including judges falling on stony places and bones scattered as at a grave, images of harsh reversal for those set against him.

Verse 8-10

The psalm closes with eyes fixed on God as refuge, pleading to be kept from the snares laid by evildoers, and asking that the wicked fall into their own nets while David himself passes by safely.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine prayer for protection from enemies is incomplete without an accompanying prayer for internal discipline—guarded words, a heart resistant to evil influence, and humility to receive correction from godly friends. The psalm refuses to treat external danger and internal integrity as separate concerns, asking God to address both together.

Application for life today.

Make verse 3 a specific daily prayer—asking God to set a watch over your mouth—especially in situations where you know your speech tends toward harm or excess. Consider whether you currently welcome correction from godly friends as 'excellent oil,' as verse 5 describes, or resist it as an insult. Notice how this psalm holds guarding your own heart and praying against external threats

together; examine whether your own prayers tend to neglect one for the other.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What situation this week would benefit from praying verse 3 specifically—asking God to set a watch over your mouth before you speak?

2. Do you currently receive correction from godly friends as 'excellent oil' (v. 5), or do you tend to resist and resent it?

3. How does this psalm's combination of guarding your own heart and praying against external danger challenge you to hold both together rather than focusing on just one?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).